Product People

Saturday, October 24, 2026 *6 Articles*

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Weekly Dose of Optimism #216

Packy McCormick · Not Boring by Packy McCormick · October 23, 2026

Hi friends 👋, Happy Friday and welcome to the 216th Weekly Dose of Optimism!

It looks like the hacks this week broke a lot of the internet, but over here in our little corner of it, things are looking good. We have everything from cancer to plant communications to genetically engineered war dogs to basically alchemy. Once again, the week was so jam packed that we have more in the Extra Dose (7 Extras!) than we do up top.

Let's get to it.

This week's Weekly Dose is brought to you by… Reducto
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(1) FDA Approves Rectal Cancer Immunotherapy (+ more)

U.S. Food and Drug Administration, Jeff Tang, Coherence Neuro; video created with Runway

We hate cancer here at the Dose, and we're not afraid to say it. It's probably why not a single cancer reads the Dose. We're willing to sacrifice our numbers for our belief.

Consequently, we love when humans come up with new ways to kill cancer, and they've done it once again (and again, and again) this week.

In June 2022, in a small trial at Memorial Sloan Kettering, twelve patients with locally advanced rectal cancer took six months of an immunotherapy called dostarlimab. In all twelve, the cancer disappeared without chemo, radiation, or surgery.

On Monday, the FDA granted dostarlimab (GSK's Jemperli) accelerated approval as a standalone first treatment for stage II and III rectal cancers that are mismatch repair deficient (dMMR). These tumors basically have a broken DNA spell-checker, so mutations pile up until the cancer looks foreign to the immune system. Dostarlimab blocks PD-1, the off switch tumors use to keep T cells at bay, which lets the immune system clear the cancer (explained in the video above).

In GSK's 154-patient trial, after a median of 26 months, cancer hadn't progressed in 71% of patients treated with dostarlimab alone. In MSK's expanded 50-patient study, every patient responded, and 93% stayed cancer-free for at least a year.

Only about 3% of locally advanced rectal cancers are dMMR, per the FDA, so this isn't a cure for all rectal cancers, let alone all cancer, but we're getting into a pretty consistent, almost weekly, pattern of new therapies working against specific cancers, which seems like the way we'll beat cancer overall.

In some cases, individuals are even figuring out how to cure their own, n-of-1 specific cancer.

In #177 we led with Elliot's story on one of those people, GitLab founder Sid Sijbrandij, going founder mode on his osteosarcoma after running out of standard options. He's one of six people Jeff Tang included in a list of those who have cured or are curing their own cancer, or a loved one's.

Jeff Tang@jefftangx

People who cured / are curing their own cancer on X:

1/ @sytses - bone cancer, billionaire founder of Gitlab, developed 10+ personalized therapies for himself. 2/ @paul_conyngham - shrank his dog Rosie's mast cell cancer tumors after chemo and surgery weren't enough. Now…

4:20 AM · Oct 21, 2026 · 401KViews

95Replies · 587Reposts · 4.55KLikesBut wait, there's more!

On Wednesday, Coherence Neuro announced that it had raised a $45M Series A from Founders Fund and OpenAI "to build cancer therapy that learns."

Ben Woodington@WoodingtonBen

We've raised a $45m Series A, co-led by

@foundersfund and The @OpenAI Startup Fund, to build cancer therapy that learns. Technology is rapidly changing medicine, but data loops and rapid adjustments are still largely missing. When you start cancer treatment, knowing whether …

2:26 PM · Oct 21, 2026 · 100KViews

73Replies · 64Reposts · 701LikesThe idea is to turn neurotech and BCIs at cancer to read the electrical signals surrounding it, understand how it grows over time, and influence the electrical signals to modulate the disease. Human trials are underway in glioblastoma patients, and they're gearing up for pancreatic cancer and more.

There's a long way to go on these and so many of the cancer treatments we discuss in the Dose, but the promising results have become a drumbeat, and it really does seem like we're on the path to knocking out cancer once and for all.

So say it with me, as heartily as you can: get fucked, cancer.

(2) The Nuclear Company Proposes a 6.6 GW KY Nuclear Campus

Alexander C. Kaufman for Heatmap

As much as we hate cancer, that's how much we at the Dose love nuclear power.

We love small nuclear reactors, and we love big nuclear reactors, and we especially love a lot of either. Big week for us, then.

It hasn't always been so good for nuclear here in the US. In the roughly 15 years it took the US to finish its first two Westinghouse AP1000 reactors at Vogtle, China built four of them, then they reverse-engineered the design into its own Hualong One, and now they have 10 Hualongs running with at least 37 more on the way. China knows that the way to make nuclear cheap is to make a lot of reactors over and over.

The Nuclear Company, which employs a bunch of people who worked and learned on Vogtle, launched in 2024 to do just that.

On Wednesday, it announced Prosperity One, a proposed campus for up to **six AP1000s, about 6.6 GW**, on roughly 4,000 acres along the Ohio River in Lewis County, Kentucky.

6.6 GW is an enormous amount of power. Fully built, Prosperity One would be the largest nuclear site in the US and account for over 5% of the country's total nuclear capacity (we're at 97GW right now).

TNC's plan is to build two units at a time, keeping the design consistent on each, so that it can bring down costs on each successive one, a lesson learned the hard way at Vogtle. After a slow, expensive start with Unit 3, Vogtle Unit 4 came in roughly 30% cheaper and faster. TNC Chief Nuclear Officer Joe Klecha said that 30% is the floor expected savings. The company is targeting 2028 NRC approval.

At the other end of the size spectrum, the Navy picked Radiant to install its Kaleidos microreactor at Naval Weapons Station Crane in Indiana. Kaleidos is a factory-built, 1 MW reactor (6,600 times smaller than Prosperity One), that is built centrally and shipped to sites by truck, ship, or plane. When completed (the Navy wants 2028), it will be the Navy's first shore-based advanced reactor and the first power-producing reactor in Indiana. Radiant, which we wrote a Deep Dive on in 2024, now has partnerships with the Army, Navy, and Air Force.

ELECTRONAISSANCE.

(3) Ben Lamm and Palmer Luckey Launch Warhound

I already had this whole thing written, with a different story in this slot, when the news dropped that Colossal Biosciences' Ben Lamm and Andruil's Palmer Luckey were teaming up to launch Warhound with a fresh $200M from investors including In-Q-Tel, Sequoia, and 8VC. The new company is worth $1.2 billion.

This is the advanced technology version of a superhero movie, literally in that we're talking about genetically engineered war dogs and figuratively in that we're seeing two characters combining forces within a wider cinematic universe. Per the website, Warhound is "combining licensed technology from Colossal Biosciences and Anduril," which is just a really interesting way to start a new business.

"Animal welfare is central to that mission," the company says on its website, "with American Humane certification supporting our commitment to the care and well-being of every dog."

I don't think I'm going to be able to say anything Lamm didn't, so Per TechCrunch:

> *Lamm believed dogs could be enhanced for health, longevity, and "for things like speed and agility or enhance olfactory sensors for bomb sniffing and whatnot," he said. His team looked at the top-performing working dog breeds — the Belgian Malinois and German Shepherd — taking the cell lines from them and putting them in a biobank. From there, they will edit the genes, adding the ones that will make the dogs perform better while taking out the ones that won't, to create "a new type of dog."*
>
> *Andruil, meanwhile, will provide software and hardware enhancement for items such as dog protection vests and eye goggles to assist the dogs and their handlers with matters like situational awareness and coordination.*
>
> *"The idea is, if we make the dog safer, make it healthier, make it perform better, it's going to perform better in the line of duty," Lamm said. He added that Anduril's additions aim to make the dogs safer and healthier outside of their genetic components, "on top of the dog, not in the dog." He believes such enhancements will also protect the dogs' human handlers better.*

This is not a new structure for Lamm. In late 2022, Lamm co-founded Form Bio, a software company spun out of Colossal, and he later launched Breaking as another spinout. As with Warhound, Colossal will own equity (Luckey won't), but this time, it's combining technological forces with another company, Anduril.

They're good dogs, Brent. 16/10 please thank them for their service.

(4) Doris Tsao's Lab Finds Signs of Consciousness in Time

Janis Hesse, Doris Tsao, et al. on bioRxiv, video created with Runway

Late last year, in Dose #173, we covered Dr. Doris Tsao's joining our friends at Astera to lead a new team, Astera Neuro. "The new team's goal is to solve one of the longest-standing, most fundamental questions: how the brain produces conscious experience, cognition, and intelligent behavior."

Just ten months later, Tsao and team are out with their first big paper, and it's a doozy. The video above is one attempt to explain it, and here's the word version.

If you show your left eye one face and your right eye another, you see just one face. Instead of blending them, one just vanishes from awareness, even though it's hitting your retina. Neuroscientists use this trick, called binocular flash suppression, to separate what the brain receives from what it's aware of.

The textbook belief has been that this happens because the suppressed image fades as signals move forward through the brain and never "ignites" into awareness. Last week, a team led by Janis Hesse in Tsao's lab found a different explanation.

Recording thousands of neurons in the face-processing regions of two macaques' inferotemporal and prefrontal cortex, they found that the same neurons alternate roughly every 60 milliseconds between representing the face the monkey is aware of and the one it isn't. When they reconstruct an image from one set of moments, they get the conscious face. But when they reconstructed it from the others, they got the suppressed face in full detail.

So why are we only aware of one? Still need to figure that out.

But Tsao called it the most important discovery of her career, because it means that a decodable signal deep in the brain exists even for things you're not conscious of, so scientists can now follow both faces and figure out exactly why we become aware of one and not the other, which should give deeper clues to how consciousness works.

Human consciousness research is one of the areas I'm most fascinated by, and I hope that this is the first of many breakthroughs from Astera Neuro and others.

(4a) Electric Plant Company Releases Bombadil to Speak Plant

As we better understand our own human brains, humans are also making progress in understanding the language of… plants.

Electric Plant came out of stealth this week with $11.2 million in funding and a foundation model, Bombadil, that reads electrical signals from inside living plants and translates them to estimate seven kinds of stress, like thirst and nutrient needs. Bombadil was pretrained on more than 4 million hours of recordings from 100 species, from redwoods to tomatoes, captured with sensors that cost tens of dollars. Co-founder Justin Mast, who founded Bloomscape, compares it to one model that reads the brainwaves of blue whales, horseshoe crabs, and fruit flies, given how diverse plant species are.

Practically, in the near-term, the company thinks it can cut farm water use by 20% or more with its models and sensors, which is important and economical, but more wildly…we are learning the language of plants? And it's bioelectric?

I got to see a preview of this at Onto Ventures' summit in California a couple weeks ago and it was one of the most mindblowing demoes I've seen. Justin is kind of like the Lorax, but he speaks *to*the trees.

(5) Marathon Fusion Says It Turned Mercury Into Gold

We cover a lot of impressive accomplishments in the Dose, like talking to plants and curing cancer, but it's not every day that we cover a company that's succeeded where the inimitable Sir Isaac Newton failed.

That's what Marathon Fusion has done. Newton, under the pseudonym Jeova Sanctus Unus, spent three decades trying to crack alchemy, as I wrote about in *Take Weird Ideas Seriously.*I think it's great that he tried. He just didn't have the technology.

Marathon Fusion seems to. Co-founded in 2023 by CEO Kyle Schiller and CTO Adam Rutkowski, a former SpaceX propulsion engineer, the company posted that last month it turned mercury into "real, stable gold" at ten times the rate of CERN's 2025 record. CERN's version produced about 29 picograms across four years of collider runs, so we're not talking Fort Knox, but the physics is real. Fast neutrons from a deuterium-tritium fusion reaction knock a neutron out of mercury-198, which becomes mercury-197 and decays into gold over a few days.

Gold dropped pretty hard yesterday (unsure if related), but for now, it's just a demonstration.

In the nearer-term, Marathon will use the technology to make medical isotopes. Neutrons that can turn mercury into gold can also turn zinc into copper-64 and copper-67, used in cancer imaging and targeted radiotherapy. Marathon says it has started making both.

The neutrons can make a lot of things. In August, outside testing lab Covalent certified that Marathon's plasma centrifuge had enriched lithium-6, which fusion plants need to breed tritium fuel, and this week the company said a new run beat a Soviet record that had stood for 40 years. Next is a fusion reactor in San Francisco designed to fire a trillion neutrons a second into a one-centimeter target, continuously, for years.

It's a very Fuse-like bet that the neutrons produced in fusion reactions can be very valuable long before Q>whatever, and a Small Steps approach to fusion.

Or as Mike Meyers would say, "I LOVE GOOOOOOOOLD."

EXTRA DOSES: Science Breakthroughs, a16z Frontier, Formic $50M, Warp Sciences, Chinese Cancer Drugs and the FDA, Gecko Navy, Patrick Hsu on Dialectic

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🧠 Community Wisdom: Negotiating a lowball offer, designers earning a seat in product decisions, resources for building an MCP server, and more

Kiyani · Lenny's Newsletter · October 24, 2026

👋 *Hello and welcome to this week's edition of* ✨ ***Community Wisdom*** ✨ *a subscriber-only email, delivered every Saturday, highlighting the most helpful conversations in our members-only Slack community.*

Claude Duet is beautiful. I still forgot to use it

Claire Vo · Lenny's Newsletter · October 21, 2026

Anthropic's new personal agent, Claude Duet, lives on your phone, inherits all your Claude plugins and connectors, and is pitched at small business owners and busy professionals. It's the most polished agent launch I've seen: thoughtful onboarding, task lists, first-class artifacts, and Slack-style channels. But polish isn't enough when you're competing with every other personal agent for attention. I put it to work on my inbox and Slack, my sales pipeline, a Google Docs sales deck, a launch video, and finding Warriors tickets for my kids, and I'll walk you through what

it nails, where it stalls, and what Anthropic needs to fix before it can become anyone's number one agent.

Listen or watch on YouTube, Spotify, or Apple Podcasts

What you'll learn:

1. What Claude Duet is and who Anthropic built it for
2. The design details that make it far more polished than other personal agent launches
3. How task lists, artifacts, and channels work as agent primitives
4. Why a "proactive" agent that never nudges you is a growth problem
5. How model latency kills your willingness to work with an agent synchronously
6. Where it fell short on real tasks, from inbox triage to sales decks to launch videos
7. Why missing desktop and multiplayer support keeps it out of my working stack

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In this episode, we cover:

(00:00) Personal agent fatigue: does Claude Duet make the cut?

(00:40) What Claude Duet is and who it's for

(01:39) Why the design polish stands out

(03:06) Task lists, artifacts, and channels

(04:53) The icon

(05:27) What I didn't like: not proactive enough

(07:02) Testing it on email, Slack, and Warriors tickets

(07:41) Why latency matters so much in a personal agent

(10:20) The missing desktop app

(12:12) Sales pipeline and a Google Docs deck

(13:10) Launch videos and the local skills gap

(14:00) Single-player vs. multiplayer agents

(15:05) Final verdict

Tools referenced:

• Claude Duet (Anthropic): https://claude.com/resources/articles/claude-duet

• Claude Duet Waitlist: https://claude.com/product/claude-duet

• Claude Cowork: https://claude.com/product/cowork

• Meta Muse: https://muse.ai/

• Codex (OpenAI): https://openai.com/codex

• Grok Bot: https://x.ai/bot

Where to find Claire Vo:

ChatPRD: https://www.chatprd.ai/

Website: https://clairevo.com/

LinkedIn: https://www.linkedin.com/in/clairevo/

X: https://x.com/clairevo

Production and marketing by https://penname.co/. For inquiries about sponsoring the podcast, email .

🎙️ How I AI: Meta Muse Wonder + How Brooke Lacey is scaling video with AI

Lenny Rachitsky · Lenny's Newsletter · October 19, 2026

Meta's new Muse Wonder model: good for AI agents, bad for design

Listen now on **YouTube • Spotify • Apple Podcasts**

Brought to you by:

- **DX**—Engineering intelligence for the AI era
- **Jira Product Discovery**—Prioritize with insights, build with confidence

Claire puts Meta's new Muse Wonder model through nearly 20 real-world tasks covering agentic work, coding, writing, design, and video editing. She explains why its active focus mode made it especially strong at billing support, inbox triage, computer use, and email writing, while its prototypes and visual work consistently fell short. She also shares how Muse compares with Opus 5.5, Astra, and Fable, and why she plans to test it in a few agent workflows without letting it anywhere near her front end.

Biggest takeaways:

1. **Muse Wonder is the strongest agentic model Claire has tested at its price tier.** It ranked first on billing-ticket resolution, inbox triage, computer use, and email writing. Its advantage was clearest on long-running tasks, where it kept trying different approaches until it reached the goal.
2. **Muse Wonder's "active focus" appears to be a real capability.** The model spent more time on complex agentic tasks than on quick requests, and the stronger results reflected that additional effort. Claire saw a clearer connection between

time spent and output quality than she did with competing models.

3. **The billing-ticket benchmark shows whether an agent can function in a real SaaS environment.** Muse corrected an account-linking error, handled duplicate refund logic, changed the customer's plan, drafted a reply, and closed the ticket. It also resisted a prompt-injection attempt and resolved every planted complication.
4. **Claire would trust Muse Wonder to write emails on her behalf.** It matched her concise, two-sentence style without becoming formal or verbose. Its voice performance was similarly natural and conversational, landing close to Sonnet's quality in her testing.
5. **Muse Wonder should not be trusted with frontend design.** Its work defaults to heavy serif fonts, blurple, rounded corners, and generic SaaS layouts. On the ChatPRD redesign, it ignored the brand guidelines, added emojis, broke image rendering, and produced something disconnected from the original site.
6. **Getting 80% of a prototype right is very different from finishing it.** Muse often created convincing scaffolding, then failed during interaction testing with broken buttons, incorrect themes, and obstructive overlays. Its biggest weakness wasn't generating the interface but completing it with visual polish and functional fidelity.
7. **Muse Wonder has promising video-editing instincts but weak visual execution.** It found the right 40-second segment, chose music Claire liked, and nearly nailed the cut timing. Poor overlays, badly placed captions, and flawed audio treatment kept the result from feeling finished.
8. **Muse Wonder's speed depends heavily on the task.** It moves quickly through SVGs, short prototypes, and other one-shot requests but slows considerably during inbox triage, backend implementation, and video editing. That difference likely reflects active focus spending more time on complex goals.
9. **Muse Wonder has earned a place in Claire's experiments, but not as her daily driver.** She plans to test it inside a few agent workflows because its multi-step reasoning and natural voice are strong. It is especially promising for personal agents and knowledge-work orchestration, as long as the job does not involve design.

Blog and detailed workflow walkthroughs from this episode:

Meta Muse Wonder Review: Agents, Coding, and Design: https://www.chatprd.ai/how-i-ai/meta-muse-wonder-review

↳ How to Set Up Meta's Muse Wonder for Headless AI Testing: https://www.chatprd.ai/how-i-ai/workflows/muse-wonder-headless-testing

↳ How to Test an AI Agent for Complex Customer Support Ticket Resolution: https://www.chatprd.ai/how-i-ai/workflows/ai-agent-billing-ticket-benchmark

"Claude cuts my TikTok": How this creator is scaling video with AI | Brooke Lacey

Listen now on **YouTube • Spotify • Apple Podcasts**

Brought to you by:

- **Firecrawl**—Give your AI agents web data and beyond
- **Auros**—The human network behind AI

Brooke Lacey is a longtime technologist and creator who has built an audience of more than 290,000 followers on TikTok. In this episode, she shows how she uses Claude Code, FFmpeg, and Whisper to turn a raw phone recording into a fully edited, captioned video in about 15 seconds, all without uploading the footage or opening a traditional editor. She also explains how she trained Claude on her exact jump-cut cadence, mines audience comments for new scripts, and runs her projects through a personal operating system built inside Claude Code.

Biggest takeaways:

1. **Brooke replaced a traditional video editor with a terminal and three simple tools.** Her TikTok workflow uses FFmpeg, Whisper, and Python, orchestrated by Claude Code. A raw phone video goes in, and about 15 seconds later, a finished vertical short comes out with captions, jump cuts, and zooms.
2. **In Brooke's workflow, the entire edit lives in a text file.** Each row of a TSV defines the start time, end time, shot size, and label for a cut. Once Claude creates that file, the same command can generate 15-, 30-, and 60-second versions, plus a landscape crop, from one raw take.
3. **Brooke taught Claude to recognize her comedic timing.** Instead of simply cutting silences, it learned the cadence of her voice, the pause before a punchline, the ideal cut point after a word, and

which repeated take had the best rhythm. Encoding that style required deliberate instruction and iteration, not one clever prompt.

4. **A TikTok comment section can become an ongoing content brief.** Brooke connects each video with its comments, then asks Claude Code to identify what viewers questioned, debated, or wanted next. The result is a list of new ideas grounded in signals from her actual audience.
5. **Creators need to understand the craft before they can delegate it.** Brooke could teach Claude to edit in her style because she already knew what a good cut sounded like, where a zoom should land, and why the timing mattered. AI amplifies that judgment, but it does not replace the experience required to develop it.
6. **A personal AI operating system is more useful than a collection of prompts.** Brooke's "lane OS" gives Claude Code separate memory, permissions, and status files for each product. When the system makes a mistake, she traces it back to the relevant instructions and records the correction globally so the mistake doesn't recur.
7. **Experienced technologists bring valuable perspective to new platform shifts.** Brooke has lived through Windows 3.1, the rise of the internet, Y2K, and today's AI transition. That history helps her recognize genuine platform changes without panicking, and she believes more experienced operators should share that perspective instead of watching from the sidelines.
8. **Posting once a week can be enough when the foundation is strong.** Brooke has built an audience while publishing about weekly, with older videos continuing to resurface. Her Claude Code workflow didn't help her post more; it removed hours of editing friction so each video no longer consumes an entire day.

Blog and detailed workflow walkthroughs from this episode:

Claude Code Can Edit a TikTok. Teaching It What's Funny Is the Hard Part.: https://www.chatprd.ai/how-i-ai/brooke-lacey-claude-code-video-editing

↳ Automate Short-Form Video Editing with Claude Code, FFmpeg, and Whisper: https://www.chatprd.ai/how-i-ai/workflows/claude-code-short-form-video-editing

↳ Generate New Video Ideas by Analyzing Your TikTok Comments with Claude: https://www.chatprd.ai/how-i-ai/workflows/claude-tiktok-comments-content-ideas

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If you're enjoying these episodes, reply and let me know what you'd love to learn more about: AI workflows, hiring, growth, product strategy—anything.

Catch you next week,
Lenny

P.S. Want every new episode delivered the moment it drops? Hit "Follow" on your favorite podcast app.

"Claude cuts my TikTok": How this creator is scaling video with AI | Brooke Lacey

Claire Vo · Lenny's Newsletter · October 19, 2026

Brooke Lacey has been making videos since before Facebook had video, and she built a TikTok audience of more than 290,000 by learning to cut short-form videos herself. With over 25 years in tech, she now builds her own apps, including Zosha, a free mobile app for learning AI. In this episode, Brooke walks me through the Claude Code, FFmpeg, and Whisper workflow that edits her TikToks in about 15 seconds, how she mines her comments for new scripts, and how she runs a weekly short-form operation with no editor.

Listen or watch on YouTube, Spotify, or Apple Podcasts

What you'll learn:

1. How Claude Code edits a raw phone video on her computer in about 15 seconds
2. How she taught Claude her jump-cut cadence
3. Why her TikTok comments became her content brief
4. How she keeps growing her audience while posting just once a week—and what's next
5. What over 25 years in tech taught her about this AI moment

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Firecrawl—Give your AI agents web data and beyond

Auros—The human network behind AI

In this episode, we cover:

(00:00) Intro and guest welcome
(02:30) Brooke's background in video

(06:56) Her first session cutting videos with Claude Code

(08:51) Live demo: Claude edits a video in real time

(11:05) Walking through the edit chain

(15:58) How she taught Claude her cadence, her hooks, and what funny sounds like

(25:36) Quick recap

(26:20) Posting frequency, live streaming plans, and TikTok ads

(28:00) Lightning round: Gen X, wisened experience, and YOLO energy

(32:43) When Claude disappoints: the lane OS, status files, and how she prompts it back

(34:50) Where to find Brooke and the Zosha app

Tools referenced:

• Claude Code: https://claude.ai/code

• FFmpeg: https://ffmpeg.org

• Whisper (OpenAI): https://openai.com/research/whisper

Other reference:

• How I AI episode with John Blackman (91-year-old vibe coder): https://www.lennysnewsletter.com/p/how-a-91-year-old-vibe-coded-a-complex?utm_source=publication-search

Where to find Brooke:

TikTok: https://www.tiktok.com/@brookejlacey

X: https://x.com/brookejlacey

Zosha app: http://zosha.app/

Where to find Claire Vo:

ChatPRD: https://www.chatprd.ai/

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LinkedIn: https://www.linkedin.com/in/clairevo/

X: https://x.com/clairevo

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Inside the black box of AI: How AI models actually think | Emmanuel Ameisen (Anthropic)

Lenny Rachitsky · Lenny's Newsletter · October 18, 2026

Emmanuel Ameisen is an interpretability researcher at Anthropic, where he looks inside LLMs like Claude to understand how they think. Before joining Anthropic, he spent years in applied ML at Stripe and Insight, and is the author of *Building Machine Learning Powered Applications*. His research has produced some of the most striking findings in the field: that models form general representations of concepts, plan many tokens ahead without stating those plans explicitly, and may exhibit something structurally similar to the distinction between conscious and unconscious processing in humans.

Listen on YouTube, Spotify, or Apple Podcasts

We discuss:

1. Why the "next-token predictor" framing undersells how models actually plan and think
2. Why anthropomorphizing AI can actually be the right approach
3. Why models are "grown," not built
4. What the "J space" reveals about model self-awareness
5. The smooth scaling curve behind what look like sudden capability jumps
6. How interpretability connects to AI alignment and safety

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Where to find Emmanuel Ameisen:



X: https://x.com/mlpowered • LinkedIn: https://www.linkedin.com/in/ameisen

• Website: https://www.mlpowered.com

Referenced:

• Chris Olah on X: https://x.com/ch402

• Distill: https://distill.pub

• Ilya Sutskever on X: https://x.com/ilyasut

• Tracing the thoughts of a large language model: https://www.anthropic.com/research/tracing-thoughts-language-model

• A global workspace in language models: https://www.anthropic.com/research/global-workspace

• Scaling Laws for Neural Language Models: https://arxiv.org/abs/2001.08361

• Head of Claude Code: What happens after coding is solved | Boris Cherny: https://www.lennysnewsletter.com/p/head-of-claude-code-what-happens

• Claude's Constitution: https://www.anthropic.com/constitution

• Golden Gate Claude: https://www.anthropic.com/news/golden-gate-claude

• The Rise and Fall of Agent Civilizations: The whole OpenAI/Hugging Face story in plain English: https://www.dwarkesh.com/p/openai-huggingface

• The Utility of Interpretability — Emmanuel Ameisen, Anthropic: https://www.latent.space/p/circuit-tracing

• Swyx on X: https://x.com/swyx

• Jev for beginners: how to use it and what to build: https://www.lennysnewsletter.com/p/jev-for-beginners-how-to-use-it-and

• Jev: https://typesafe.ai/blog/introducing-system-one-models-and-jev

• What is System 1 and System 2 Thinking?: https://thedecisionlab.com/reference-guide/philosophy/system-1-and-system-2-thinking

• Neuronpedia: https://www.neuronpedia.org

• *Obsession*: https://www.imdb.com/title/tt37287335

• *Bref 2*on Hulu: https://www.hulu.com/series/bref 2-251c6388-18e9-4545-9e5d-d5f3f6bf20d7

• Apple Watch Ultra: https://www.apple.com/apple-watch-ultra-4

Recommended books:

• *A Brief History of Intelligence: Evolution, AI, and the Five Breakthroughs That Made Our Brains*: https://www.amazon.com/dp/0063286343

• *Stories of Your Life and Others*: https://www.amazon.com/Stories-Your-Life-Others-Chiang/dp/1101972122

• *Four Thousand Weeks*: https://www.amazon.com/Four-Thousand-Weeks-Management-Mortals/dp/1250849357

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Lenny may be an investor in the companies discussed.

My biggest takeaways from this conversation: